
“HSBC tried to keep me on in advisory roles, but I wanted to break with banking and move on to other things, a decision I’ve never regretted because it’s given me the ability to not be a slave to others”

world. You know, the funds are not easy to come by. And, if I didn’t have that other half, the half that I know well—the world of banking and investment banking and finance—to keep me going, I think it would sometimes get me down because it can be a very difficult and frustrating world.

But I’ve learnt through all the wonderful people I work with in the NGO space, how to indeed keep a smile on my face even when I’m fuming and fretting and worrying about all that needs to happen, but doesn’t happen! They are two very different worlds actually, and you need very different strengths in each.

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Q: You are a business leader in your own right but the celebrity status around you is also because you are a woman who achieved all that. Were you always aware of some extra scrutiny attached to you because you were a woman, that the yardsticks of judgement were different?

A: Sadly, I would say yes. And I think that scrutiny starts very early in our careers as women. Even in the days when I was at Grindlays Bank, as one of the first few senior women bankers in the early ’80s, I felt like a goldfish in a bowl. You always felt you were on display. There were people just waiting to see you fall and say oh, see, this is what it was about. For every woman who took maternity leave, it was another slight, and I was very conscious of the fact and therefore under a lot of pressure personally—for everything that I did, if it turned out wrong, it would not just be a blot against my name, but possibly against all women that were to follow. That puts one under immense pressure.

I don’t think that has gone away completely because we still represent other women, not just ourselves as individuals in our careers as we go. So, that pressure is something one just gets used to living with. And that scrutiny never ends, so when you fall, you are noticed much more than when you succeed. Though fortunately, that too gets noticed.

